

MANISH KOTHAWADE

Automotive Quality Leader | Plant Quality Manager | IATF 16949 Lead Auditor | ASQ CQE, CMQ/OE, CSQP
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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Strategic automotive Quality Leader with 15+ years of progressive experience across Tier 1 manufacturing, JIT operations, multi-site QMS leadership, supplier quality, and OEM customer management. Proven record leading quality organizations in high-volume environments supporting Ford, Stellantis, BMW, GM, Honda, and Nissan, with measurable results in audit performance, customer scorecards, containment reduction, warranty improvement, supplier responsiveness, and digital QMS transformation. ASQ CQE, CMQ/OE, CSQP, IATF 16949 Lead Auditor, invited AIAG/IATF/IAOB standards contributor, and published ASQ quality author.

SELECTED LEADERSHIP IMPACT

- Led quality for an \$800M+ Ford-dedicated JIT seating operation supporting Ford Explorer and Lincoln Aviator programs, directing a direct team of 12 with indirect authority over 30+ quality resources across a 24/7 facility.
- Improved Ford Customer Scorecard from 82 to 99 while maintaining Ford Q1 Preferred Quality Status.
- Achieved zero nonconformities across three consecutive IATF 16949 third-party audits across recent plant and corporate QMS leadership roles.
- Reduced open containment from 100% to 1% through structured root cause analysis and layered containment verification.
- Managed supplier quality for 15+ Tier 2 suppliers across 1,600+ part numbers, leading all Plant APQP and PPAP activity for new product launches.
- Invited contributor to three AIAG/IATF/IAOB automotive quality standards-development workgroups shaping future IATF 16949 and CQI-39 requirements.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Plant Quality Leadership | OEM Customer Quality | JIT Manufacturing | Supplier Quality & Development
IATF 16949 / ISO 9001 QMS | Audit Readiness | Layered Process Audits | CSR Compliance
APQP | PPAP | FMEA | MSA | SPC | 8D | CAPA | RCA | Warranty / Field Action Support
QMS Digital Transformation | Palantir Foundry / Copilot | Lean Six Sigma | Team Development

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Lear Corporation

March 2024 – Present

Hammond, IN | **Plant Quality Manager**

Lead plant quality operations for an \$800M+ sole-source, Ford-dedicated JIT seating facility supporting Ford Explorer (U611) and Lincoln Aviator (U625) programs, with full responsibility for customer quality, launch quality, supplier quality, audit readiness, containment, escalation management, and quality systems performance. Lead a direct team of 12 quality professionals with indirect authority over 30+ quality resources across a 24/7 operation.

- Improved Ford Customer Scorecard from 82 to 99 and maintained Ford Q1 Preferred Quality Status through consistent performance and proactive customer engagement.
- Achieved zero nonconformities across Lear Hammond's IATF 16949 third-party audits through disciplined system ownership and a cross-functional audit readiness culture.
- Reduced open containment from 100% to 1% through rigorous root cause analysis and structured layered containment verification, reducing defect escape risk and improving customer protection.
- Played a central technical role in the customer-facing response to two concurrent Ford field service actions affecting 540,000+ vehicles, leading forensic traceability analysis, affected-population characterization, containment verification, corrective-action coordination, and customer documentation.
- Managed supplier quality for 15+ Tier 2 suppliers across 1,600+ part numbers; led all plant APQP and customer/supplier PPAP for new product launches.
- Integrated Microsoft Copilot and Palantir Foundry into quality response workflows, improving speed of customer response, data retrieval, trend analysis, and escalation readiness.
- Developed custom quality software tools including a real-time containment tracking and shift-level monitoring application purpose-built for the Ford Explorer and Lincoln Aviator seating programs.

- Delivered downward trend in IPPM and improved off-shift quality performance through structured Cold Build Boundary Book and layered process audit implementation.

Motus Integrated Technologies

August 2023 – December 2023

*Holland / Battle Creek, MI | **Global Operations Quality Manager***

- Resolved 6-month backlog of chronic customer issues using Trend Pareto Attack (TPA) methodology, achieving 80% PPM reduction in the top defect category.
- Accelerated closure of 6 longstanding Stellantis MPA nonconformities within 3 weeks via Reverse FMEA, Lessons Learned Database, and LPA deployment.
- Digitized CQI-8-aligned layered process audit system managing 20+ daily / 500+ monthly audits with automated reporting and nonconformance tracking.
- Led global 8D program across multiple Motus plants, reducing 8Ds open longer than 3 years by 10%.

Wolverine Metal Stampings

March 2020 – August 2023

*Saint Joseph, MI | **Quality Systems Manager***

- Rebuilt and matured a multi-site QMS from unstable audit performance to sustained third-party audit readiness, supporting zero major nonconformities and improved customer confidence across Michigan and North American facilities.
- Served as Corporate QMS Liaison across multiple North American facilities, leading all 2nd and 3rd party IATF 16949 / ISO 9001 audits.
- Increased quality team retention by 40% through transparent communication, development coaching, and career growth investment.
- Applied Six Sigma methodologies to eliminate waste, delivering \$100K+ in annual cost savings.
- Implemented OpenKM document management system, realizing \$20K recurring annual savings while improving document control efficiency.
- Drove supplier responsiveness from near-zero to 100% through vendor training, onsite audits, and structured communication cadence.
- Developed digital training system reducing annual trainer time by 15%; standardized KPIs improved executive management engagement by 30%.

Kasai North America (KNA)

July 2017 – March 2020

*Murfreesboro, TN | **QMS Lead Auditor***

- Led IATF 16949 QMS transition at Corporate HQ and 5 manufacturing facilities from TS 16949 / QS 9000, completed within 8 months.
- Co-developed custom in-house CAPA software, streamlining corrective action tracking across all facilities.
- Created cross-OEM CSR Matrix integrating 6+ OEM requirements with internal processes, reducing CSR interpretation gaps and improving audit readiness.
- Trained QMS Managers at 5 facilities; conducted annual competency assessments and monthly performance reviews.

Midwest Acoust-A-Fiber Inc.

March 2016 – June 2017

*Delaware, OH | **Senior Quality Systems Engineer***

- Guided company through 2 TS 16949 and 2 CCC certification audits under certification-expiry conditions, securing \$20M+ in future business and saving \$25K in costs.
- Reduced FCA warranty claims to zero; cut weekly warranty review time from 12 to 2 hours through process redesign, achieving 50% reduction in cost of quality.

American Showa Inc.

May 2014 – March 2016

*Sunbury, OH | **Quality Assurance Engineer***

- Managed warranty PFMEA through vehicle testing and simulation; led 5+ corrective action requests monthly with cross-functional facilitation.
- Performed capability studies and MSA projects; coordinated multiple improvement projects via warranty-driven analysis.

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

Faurecia, Project Engineer, Pune, India (2011–2012) | Baker Gauges, QA Engineer, Pune, India (2010–2011) | Indo Schotte Auto Parts, Trainee QA Engineer, Pune, India (2009–2010)

INDUSTRY LEADERSHIP & STANDARDS CONTRIBUTIONS

Invited contributor to three automotive quality standards-development workgroups, including IATF 16949 2nd Edition CSR development (AIAG/IATF, 2025–Present), IAOB Operational Requirements review (2025–2026), and AIAG CQI-39 Assembly Assessment methodology (2025–Present). Contribute plant-level, supplier-quality, CSR, and operational QMS expertise to multi-stakeholder discussions involving major global OEM and industry representatives.

PUBLICATIONS & RESEARCH

Published / accepted ASQ Quality Progress author with three accepted articles covering risk-based organizational training, QMS-CSR matrix auditing, and the future of high-maturity automotive QMS and AI-supported quality workflows. Two Quality Management Journal manuscripts under peer-review revision covering heat-number risk stratification in incoming material certification and risk-based reframing of layered process audits.

EDUCATION

Master of Science, Industrial & Systems Engineering Ohio University, Athens, OH	2014
Bachelor of Engineering, Mechanical Engineering University of Pune, India	2009

CERTIFICATIONS & TECHNICAL SKILLS

ASQ Certifications: Certified Quality Engineer (CQE) | Certified Manager of Quality/OE (CMQ/OE) | Certified Supplier Quality Professional (CSQP)

Auditor Credentials: IATF 16949 Lead Auditor | ISO 9001 Lead Auditor | ISO 14001 Internal Auditor | VDA 6.3 Process Auditor

Systems & Software: PLEX, ShopEdge, SAP, MS Office Suite, OpenKM, Minitab, SharePoint, Palantir Foundry, Microsoft Copilot, HTML/JavaScript (custom quality application development)

Core Tools: APQP, PPAP, FMEA, MSA, SPC, 8D, VDA 6.1/6.3/6.5, Lean Six Sigma, ISO 9001, IATF 16949, ISO 14001, ISO 26262